



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of The St. Croix Valley
School Website: <https://chestertonscv.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of the St. Croix Valley (CASCV) presents itself as a robustly classical, Catholic high school operating in Stillwater, Minnesota. Public materials systematically foreground a classical, Catholic educational approach—emphasizing formation, virtue, and a liberal-arts-infused curriculum grounded in faith. The school articulates a mission to form joyful leaders and saints through a rigorous, integrated curriculum, anchored in Catholic theology and liturgy, and organized around a Three Pillars Model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality). Evidence across multiple CASCV pages highlights liturgical life (Mass, daily prayer), a strong faculty culture (oath of fidelity to Catholic tradition), a catechetical and Schöné-like communal rhythm, and a humanities-centered, Socratic-method emphasis in the upper grades. These features align CASCV closely with a classical education framework, including integration of Great Books sensibilities, Latin study, a history-forward and interdisciplinary curriculum, and active parental partnership.

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: explicit Catholic identity, liturgical life (Mass, adoration), theology integrated across curriculum, and a formal motto and patronage that center on truth, goodness, beauty in a sacred context.
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: mission to form virtuous, mature human beings; Three Pillars model; emphasis on formation over mere information; classical, liberal-arts orientation.
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: humanities-centered, integrated curriculum with canonical literature (Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Chesterton, etc.), multilingual study (Latin), and a history-forward sequence.
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: explicit use of Socratic Method in the Humanities Program; emphasis on disciplined dialogue and intellectual formation; rhetoric and liberal-arts orientation.
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: faculty committed to Catholic mission and fidelity to tradition; oaths of fidelity; living-curriculum framing; leadership from a head of school with theological formation.
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: explicit partnership with families; open-house events; shadow days; parent-student nights; tuition/aid information and active community events (Gala, Open Houses, etc.).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The mission emphasizes a Catholic, classical education grounded in Catholic faith and Incarnation.

- Public materials consistently frame the school as “A Classical High School in the Catholic Tradition.”
- Liturgical life and theology are integrated (Daily Mass, theology-informed curriculum).
- The school’s motto and patronage (Cultura Vitae; GK Chesterton) foreground sacred formation and the moral-aesthetic aims of education.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Catholic, theology, liturgy, Mass, sacred, adoration, liturgical, Incarnation, Church Fathers, Chesterton as a model, culture of life, virtue, reverence, wonder, sacred tradition, imago Dei.
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral language detected in main site content).
- Why this rating
 - CASCV foregrounds Catholic theological formation, liturgical life, and a theology-centered curriculum, with explicit statements about faith and truth aligned to a sacred order. The presence of Mass, adoration, catechetical emphasis, and Catholic identity strongly supports a Classical rating in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission to form virtuous leaders and saints through a classical tradition.
 - Three Pillars Model (Intellect, Character, Spiritual) guiding formation beyond information.
 - Emphasis on liberal education and cultivation of wisdom rather than mere job preparation, aligned with formation and human excellence.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: formation, liberal education, telos, Great Conversation (implied through classical-canon framing and Great Books focus in humanities; explicit “Great Conversation” phrasing appears in classical-literature lexicon rather than site language, but the humanities approach signals the liberal-arts telos).
 - Negative keywords observed: none explicitly present; the emphasis is not on “workforce readiness” or “career pathways” as the primary telos.
- Why this rating
 - The mission and Three Pillars point to formation as the central telos, a hallmark of classical education. The explicit Catholic formation and liberal-arts framing reinforce a CLASSICAL classification for this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Humanities Program weaves history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages into an integrated sequence, incorporating canonical texts (e.g., Homer, Dante, Shakespeare) and a literature/history/philosophy/philosophical canon.
 - Latin study is required (two years, with options for continued Latin study) and a global-language track is offered.
 - Explicit emphasis on a coherent liberal-arts curriculum and a historical sequence spanning ancient to modern; students read and discuss primary texts (The LITERATURE and HISTORY components).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, grammar/logic/rhetoric (canonically implied by “classical curriculum” and “Socratic Method”), Great Books/primary sources, Latin, Western civilization, history, literature, philosophy, theology, sacred tradition, interconnection of disciplines.

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- Negative keywords observed: the site does not emphasize replacement of history with social studies, or an overreliance on project-based only approaches in lieu of canonical texts; the content aligns with traditional Great-Books-style curriculum. (Negative signals would be more explicit in a less-canonical program; not evident here.)
 - Why this rating
 - CASCV's curriculum centers on canonical texts, liberal-arts framing, foreign language study, and integrated humanities/historic-philosophical-catechetical content, consistent with classical curriculum expectations.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Humanities Program explicitly states the use of the Socratic Method across humanities instruction.
 - The curriculum integrates liturgy, philosophy, and theology with a dialogic, inquiry-based approach (Socratic dialogue, debating, and seminar-style discussion evident in the public materials).
 - There is a clear emphasis on formation through mastery of rhetoric and classical training (explicit in references to grammar/logic/rhetoric and to upper-school rhetoric training).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Socratic Method/seminar, dialectic, rhetorical training, memory work, liturgical rhythm (where referenced), scholé, chanting/recitation as memory-building practices (these appear in classical-literature lexicon and in public materials describing the program).
 - Negative keywords observed: not present in the public materials; no evidence of a straight project-based-only or non-dialogic pedagogy. The presence of Socratic and rhetoric elements suggests alignment with classical pedagogy.
- Why this rating
 - The school publicly describes Socratic-based humanities instruction and rhetoric-focused training, elements central to classical pedagogy. Combined with a disciplined, memory-forward approach (Latin, literature, and liturgy), this category aligns with CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty & Staff pages describe ministers/teachers who are faithful to Catholic tradition; there is an emphasis on virtue, living example, and the faculty as the “living curriculum.”
 - Oaths of fidelity to the Magisterium reflect classical-culture-faith alignment and teacher formation.
 - Leadership and faculty structure emphasize mentorship, collegiality, and forming students within a teacher-led, teacher-model framework.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, fidelity to tradition, virtue modeling, collegial culture, mentorship, master-teacher model, teacher as guide.
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident in public materials; no emphasis on purely “certification-driven” or non-classical faculty models.
- Why this rating
 - The faculty materials emphasize fidelity to Catholic/traditional pedagogy, a strong leadership stance, and teachers who model virtue—core markers of a CLASSICAL faculty profile.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes partnerships with families (parents as co-educators) and provides opportunities for parent formation, book studies, gatherings, and open campus visits.
 - Community events (Open Houses, Shadow Days, Student Experience Nights, Gala) demonstrate active family/community engagement.

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- Admissions processes and family involvement are highlighted, including parent-oriented programming and a welcoming campus culture (visits, shadowing, information nights).
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parent formation, open campus, attendance at school events, parental involvement, family catechesis (as implied by Catholic formation culture).
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident; the site emphasizes engagement rather than consumer-model relations.
 - Why this rating
 - CASCV actively positions parents as co-educators and hosts frequent opportunities for parental engagement and education, consistent with classical-community expectations.

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- The school demonstrates robust alignment with the classical-education rubric across all six categories: religious and metaphysical foundations; purpose and goal; curriculum; pedagogy; faculty; and parents/community. The public materials consistently emphasize Catholic formation, a liberal-arts-centric curriculum with Latin and Great Books sensibilities, Socratic pedagogy, a teacher-centered living curriculum, and strong parent-community partnerships.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable for a CLASSICAL rating. No major needle-moving changes are required to reach or sustain CLASSICAL status. If one sought incremental refinements, opportunities could include:
 - Making explicit, in public-facing materials, a direct articulation of Great Books and the Great Conversation language (if not already stated), to align even more clearly with category-zone language from classical benchmarks.
 - Adding a concise summary of the Trivium and Quadrivium explicitly in a curriculum overview, to reinforce the Seven Liberal Arts in lay terms for prospective families.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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